Lesson 03: Coordination and Subordination

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 1: Refining Sentences and Punctuation

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 2.2: Coordination and Subordination.

In this lesson

You already know how to build compound and complex sentences. This lesson is about choosing between them: coordination gives two related ideas equal weight, while subordination makes one idea the main point. You also sharpen your choice of connectors, so that every connection in your academic writing says exactly what you mean.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain the difference between coordination and subordination, and choose the one that gives the emphasis you want.
- Join independent clauses with a coordinating conjunction or a conjunctive adverb, with correct punctuation.
- Join ideas with subordinating conjunctions of concession, condition, manner, place, reason and time, with correct commas.
- Choose the connector that expresses the exact relationship between two ideas, and avoid excessive coordination.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
coordination	joining two related ideas of equal importance	I spent my entire paycheck last week, so I am staying home this weekend.
subordination	joining two related ideas of unequal importance	Even though Farnaz would be late for work, she stopped to help the injured man.
compound sentence	a sentence with two independent clauses	I plan to stay home, and I will complete an essay for class.
complex sentence	a sentence with a main clause and a dependent clause	After the meeting had finished, we all went to lunch.
coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS)	for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so	I might go to the next fundraising event, or I might donate some money to the cause.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
conjunctive adverb	a linking word, used after a semicolon, that shows the relationship between two clauses	Bridget wants to take part in the next Olympics; therefore, she trains every day.
subordinating conjunction	a word that joins a dependent clause to a main clause	although, if, as if, where, because, when
dependent clause	a clause that relies on the main clause to complete its meaning	even though Farnaz would be late for work
concession	admitting a fact that seems to work against the main point	although, though, even though
consequently / thus / hence	as a result	I missed my train this morning; consequently, I was late for my meeting.
excessive coordination	joining too many clauses, or unrelated clauses, with conjunctions	the same conjunction repeated several times in one sentence

Rules and explanations

Coordination or subordination?

	Coordination	Subordination
Ideas	related and of equal importance	related but of unequal importance
Result	compound sentence: two independent clauses	complex sentence: a main clause + a dependent clause
Tools	comma + FANBOYS, or semicolon + conjunctive adverb + comma	a subordinating conjunction

- Two separate sentences ("I spent my entire paycheck last week. I am staying home this weekend.") leave the relationship unclear; a connector shows it.
- In subordination, the main clause carries the main idea: "Even though Farnaz would be late for work, she stopped to help the injured man" emphasises that she stopped to help. (The book's explanation says "Tracy"; it means Farnaz.) The dependent clause can come first or last without changing the meaning: "Farnaz stopped to help the injured man even though she would be late for work."

Coordinating conjunctions (FANBOYS)

Put a comma before the conjunction when it joins two independent clauses.

- **for** (reason), **and** (addition), **but** (contrast), **or** (alternative), **so** (result).
- **nor** adds a negative idea, and the helping verb comes before the subject: "Jessie isn't going to be at the dance, nor will Tom be there."

- **yet** shows contrast, often with something unexpected: "My parents are worried that I am antisocial, yet I have many friends at school." (The book's table says *yet* "indicates a reason"; this is a mistake, because *yet* shows contrast, as its own example shows.)

Conjunctive adverbs

Pattern: independent clause + **semicolon** + conjunctive adverb + **comma** + independent clause: "Most people do not walk to work; instead, they drive or take the train."

Function	Conjunctive adverbs
addition	also, furthermore, moreover, besides
comparison	similarly, likewise
contrast	instead, however, conversely
emphasis	namely, certainly, indeed
cause and effect	accordingly, consequently, hence, thus
time	finally, next, subsequently, then

Subordinating conjunctions

If the dependent clause comes first, put a comma after it. If it follows the main clause, usually no punctuation is needed (but a contrast clause with *whereas* normally takes a comma).

Function	Subordinating conjunctions	Book example
concession / contrast	although, while, though, whereas, even though	Sarah completed her report even though she had to stay late to get it done.
condition	if, unless, until	Until we know what is causing the problem, we will not be able to fix it.
manner	as if, as, as though	Everyone in the conference room stopped talking at once, as though they had been stunned into silence.
place	where, wherever	Rita is in San Jose where she has several important client meetings.
reason	because, since, so that, in order that	Because the air conditioning was turned up so high, everyone in the office wore sweaters.
time	after, before, while, once, when	After the meeting had finished, we all went to lunch.

To use these words precisely:

- *Although, though* and *even though* express concession ("in spite of this"); *while* and *whereas* also contrast two facts side by side.
- *Until* is mainly a time word ("up to the time when"); in the book's example it also sets a condition.
- *So that* and *in order that* express purpose (the result someone wants), not reason.
- The book's manner row prints "though"; the conjunction is *as though*.

- After a specific place name, a *where* clause adds extra information, so a comma is better: "Rita is in San Jose, where she has several important client meetings."

Use connections with judgement

- Avoid excessive coordination: join only clauses that are logically connected and make one main point. If the same conjunction appears several times in one sentence, split the sentence.
- Use subordination when one idea is background (time, condition, concession) and the other is your point.
- The excerpts from Joshua's and Jose's essays, and the section's last exercise, are pictures that are not in your printed material. Practice 4 gives similar practice.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Use one connector for one link: "Although Farnaz would be late for work, she stopped to help" (not "Although ..., but she stopped"); "Because ..., ..." (not "Because ..., so ...").
> - Arabic prose often links clause after clause with "and" or "so". In English academic writing, choose the connector that names the exact relationship (although, whereas, consequently, so that), and avoid long chains of *and*.

Practice

1. Coordination (lesson material, 2.2, first exercise). Combine each sentence pair into a single sentence using either a coordinating conjunction or a conjunctive adverb.

1. Pets are not allowed in Ms. Wallace's building. She owns several cats and a parrot.
2. New legislation prevents drivers from sending or reading text messages while driving. Many people continue to use their phones illegally.
3. The coroner concluded that the young man had taken a lethal concoction of drugs. By the time his relatives found him, nothing could be done.
4. Amphibians are vertebrates that live on land and in the water. Flatworms are invertebrates that live only in water.
5. Priya carefully fed and watered her tomato plants all summer. The tomatoes grew juicy and ripe.
6. When he lost his car key, Olamileykan attempted to open the door with a wire hanger, a credit card, and a paper clip. He called the manufacturer for advice.

2. Subordination (second exercise). Combine each sentence pair into a single sentence using a subordinating conjunction.

1. Amir is going to Mexico. There are beautiful beaches in Mexico.
2. A snowstorm disrupted traffic all over the east coast. There will be long delivery delays this week.
3. My neighbor had his television volume turned up too high. I banged on his door and asked him to keep the noise down.
4. Jessica prepared the potato salad and the sautéed vegetables. Brenda marinated the chicken.

5. Romeo poisons himself. Juliet awakes to find Romeo dead and stabs herself with a dagger.

3. Compound or complex (third exercise). Combine each set of simple sentences into a compound or a complex sentence.

1. Heroin is an extremely addictive drug. Thousands of heroin addicts die each year.
2. Shakespeare's writing is still relevant today. He wrote about timeless themes. These themes include love, hate, jealousy, death, and destiny.
3. Originally, gay marriage was legal in only six states: Iowa, Massachusetts, Connecticut, Vermont, New Hampshire, and Maine. The Supreme Court ruled it was legal in all states.
4. Prewriting is a vital stage of the writing process. Prewriting helps you organize your ideas. Types of prewriting include outlining, brainstorming, and idea mapping.
5. Ernest Hemingway is a famous writer. He also served on the local school board. His house is in Key West, Florida.

4. Change the connection (sentences from the book's tables). Rewrite each sentence as instructed, and say which idea now receives the emphasis.

1. Bridget wants to take part in the next Olympics; therefore, she trains every day. (Use a subordinating conjunction.)
2. The fundraisers are hoping for a record-breaking attendance, but I don't think many people are going. (Use a subordinating conjunction of concession.)
3. My parents are worried that I am antisocial, yet I have many friends at school. (Use *although*. Write two versions with different emphasis.)

Speak with your tutor

- "Check my answers to Practice 1 to 3: [paste]. For each sentence, tell me if another connector would be more precise."
- "Give me ten pairs of sentences about stress and coping from an introductory psychology course. I will decide whether to coordinate or subordinate each pair and explain my choice."
- "Here is a paragraph I wrote: [paste]. Where is the coordination excessive? Where would subordination show the main idea better?"
- "Let's discuss whether students should be allowed to use phones in class. After each of my answers, ask me to restate my point with *although*, *whereas* or *unless*."

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 150 to 200 words that compares two things or explains causes and effects: two ways of coping with stress (dealing with the problem itself versus managing your feelings about it), a PSYC 110 topic; two study methods (rereading notes versus testing yourself); or the effects of a new rule in your city (like the texting law in Practice 1). Use at least two coordinating conjunctions, two conjunctive adverbs from different rows of the table, and three subordinating conjunctions with different functions.

Self-editing checklist:

- Each connector shows the exact relationship (addition, contrast, concession, cause, result, condition, purpose, time).
- A comma comes before a FANBOYS word that joins two independent clauses.
- A conjunctive adverb that joins two clauses has a semicolon before it and a comma after it.
- A dependent clause at the start is followed by a comma; one at the end usually has none (except *whereas*).
- Each link has only one connector (no *although* … *but*, no *because* … *so*).
- The main idea of each sentence is in the main clause.
- No sentence strings together more than two or three clauses with *and*.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

1. Several answers are correct; the main ones are given.

1. Pets are not allowed in Ms. Wallace's building, but she owns several cats and a parrot. (Also: , yet / ; however, / ; nevertheless,)
2. New legislation prevents drivers from sending or reading text messages while driving, yet many people continue to use their phones illegally. (Also: , but / ; however, / ; nevertheless,)
3. The coroner concluded that the young man had taken a lethal concoction of drugs, and by the time his relatives found him, nothing could be done. (Also: , so / ; consequently,)
4. Amphibians are vertebrates that live on land and in the water, but flatworms are invertebrates that live only in water. (Also: ; however, / ; conversely,)
5. Priya carefully fed and watered her tomato plants all summer, so the tomatoes grew juicy and ripe. (Also: ; consequently, / ; thus,)
6. When he lost his car key, Olamileykan attempted to open the door with a wire hanger, a credit card, and a paper clip; finally, he called the manufacturer for advice. (Also: ; subsequently, / , and then)

2. The dependent clause can usually go first (with a comma) or last (usually no comma).

1. Amir is going to Mexico because there are beautiful beaches there. Also: Amir is going to Mexico, where there are beautiful beaches.
2. Because a snowstorm disrupted traffic all over the east coast, there will be long delivery delays this week. (Also: Since ...)
3. Because my neighbor had his television volume turned up too high, I banged on his door and asked him to keep the noise down. (Also: Since ... / When ...)
4. While Jessica prepared the potato salad and the sautéed vegetables, Brenda marinated the chicken. (time) Also: Jessica prepared the potato salad and the sautéed vegetables, whereas Brenda marinated the chicken. (contrast)
5. After Romeo poisons himself, Juliet awakes to find him dead and stabs herself with a dagger. (Also: Once ...)

3.

1. Because heroin is an extremely addictive drug, thousands of heroin addicts die each year. (complex) Also: Heroin is an extremely addictive drug; consequently, thousands of heroin addicts die each year. (compound)
2. Shakespeare's writing is still relevant today because he wrote about timeless themes such as love, hate, jealousy, death, and destiny. (complex; the third sentence becomes a phrase)
3. Originally, gay marriage was legal in only six states: Iowa, Massachusetts, Connecticut, Vermont, New Hampshire, and Maine; however, the Supreme Court later ruled that it was legal in all states. (compound)
4. Prewriting, which includes outlining, brainstorming, and idea mapping, is a vital stage of the writing process because it helps you organize your ideas. (complex)

5. Ernest Hemingway, a famous writer whose house is in Key West, Florida, also served on the local school board. (complex) Also: Ernest Hemingway is a famous writer whose house is in Key West, Florida, and he also served on the local school board.

4.

1. Because Bridget wants to take part in the next Olympics, she trains every day. (Or: Bridget trains every day because …) Emphasis: her daily training.
2. Although the fundraisers are hoping for a record-breaking attendance, I don't think many people are going. (Also: Even though / Though / While) Emphasis: the writer's doubt.
3. Although I have many friends at school, my parents are worried that I am antisocial. (emphasis: the parents' worry) / Although my parents are worried that I am antisocial, I have many friends at school. (emphasis: the friends, as in the original, where *yet* introduces the more important idea)

My notes